CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

ABA THERAPIST (KIDS) IN THE AI ERA

Behavior change happens in tiny, patient repetitions with a real child. Software just keeps the data.

★ **TL;DR — ABA therapy with kids at a ~$45K median (full-time equivalent) — the rare seat that hires beginners on purpose. The whole formal gate past high school is the RBT credential: a 40-hour training, a competency assessment and an exam, about 2–3 months total, and employers routinely pay for all of it. The catch: session-based pay and turnover that eats the field.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

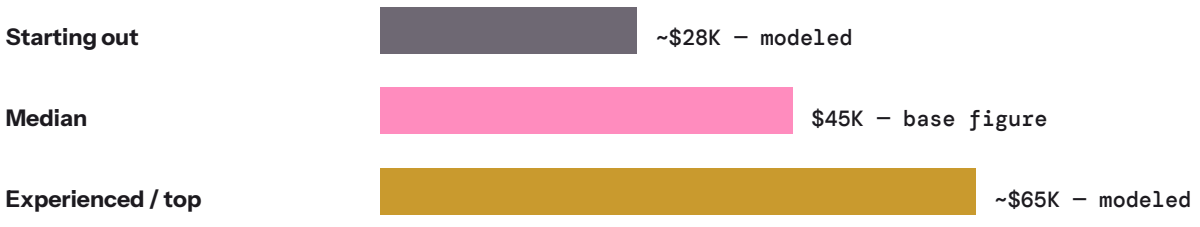
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$45K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- The demand is measured, not vibes: CDC prevalence is 1 in 31 children, ABA coverage is insurance-mandated in all 50 states, and certified RBTs grew from 89,122 (2020) to 246,109 (end of 2025).
- Pay check, honestly: the proxy occupation medians $45,100 with +18% growth, and working RBTs post around $20.52/hr — the $45K holds as a full-time figure, not a guarantee.
- AI sits in the notes, not the session: drafting tools turn session data into draft notes while the 1:1 behaviour work stays in the room with you.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for ABA Therapist (kids) is a ~$45K median (compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor

estimate)). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A ABA THERAPIST (KIDS) ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Running therapy sessions from the supervising clinician's plan
- ✓ Teaching communication and social skills through structured play
- ✓ Recording behavior data carefully, every session
- ✓ Coordinating with supervisors and updating families

Think: a coach for a team of one — running drills designed by someone else, adjusting to the player every minute.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Session-note drafting from collected data — vendor tools pitch the RBT as becoming the editor of their own notes. Paperwork minutes shrink; the billable hour doesn't.	In-the-moment behaviour management, physical prompting, safety and play-based teaching with a real child who does not follow a script. Delivered one-to-one, supervised by a clinician, in person.

⚠ TWO WARNINGS, IN WRITING. (1) Pay is session-based: part-time schedules, client cancellations and unpaid gaps mean many beginners bank less than the $45K full-time figure — get the cancellation policy in writing. (2) Turnover is very high: a 65% median in industry compilations, and 57% of lapsed RBTs in a BACB survey cited inadequate pay. And a folklore flag: the '$78,470 BLS median for behavior analysts' circulating online does not exist on any BLS page — don't plan around it.

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Play-based work with one kid at a time ✓ A credential in your name within a quarter ✓ Progress you can graph, literally	✗ Cancellations punch holes in the paycheck ✗ Hard days are physical, not theoretical ✗ Data logging after every session

Good fit? Patient, playful, observant — and you find small progress genuinely thrilling.
Bad fit? You need predictable, quiet days, or other people's emotions flood you.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — ABA PROVIDER TRAINEE	DOOR B — SCHOOL-BASED SUPPORT ROLES
The standard door, and it's wide open: clinics hire with no experience, provide the 40-hour training paid, and often cover the exam. You need to be 18+, hold a high-school diploma and pass background and abuse-registry checks. The fees are small — $65 to the BACB plus $45 to Pearson VUE — and many employers cover even those. First move: search ABA providers near you for 'no experience, training provided' postings; that phrasing is the industry norm.	School districts and their contractors hire behaviour-support staff for the same children in classroom settings — steadier hours and a school calendar, with the same RBT credential valued. It's also the natural bridge to the education side, where special-ed classrooms run on the same kinds of plans. First move: check district and agency postings for behaviour technician and aide roles, and ask whether they sponsor RBT certification.

Smart move: Choose your employer like a school. The quality of your supervising clinician decides how fast you grow — ask who supervises and how often before you sign.
Where you land after: Senior technician, then the graduate route toward supervising clinician roles.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
APPLY TO	COMPLETE THE	COMPETENCY ASSESSMENT	CARRY A	SPECIALIZE	STEP UP

STEP 1 — Apply to providers

FREE · TODAY

- Target employers who pay for training and cover exam costs — ask directly; many advertise it
- Be ready for the real gates: 18+, high-school diploma, background and abuse-registry checks

STEP 2 — Complete the 40-hour training

WEEKS 1-6

- The BACB training runs 5–180 days by rule; employer cohorts usually finish it in weeks
- Learn the vocabulary and the data sheets — precision here is the job

STEP 3 — Competency assessment + exam

MONTHS 2-3

- Pass the initial competency assessment with a qualified assessor
- Sit the RBT exam (75 scored questions, 90 minutes); BACB and Pearson fees total $110

STEP 4 — Carry a supervised caseload

MONTHS 3-6

- Run 1:1 sessions under your clinician's plan; log data every session
- Ask upfront how cancellations and non-billable time are paid — this decides your real wage

STEP 5 — Specialize MONTHS 6-10

- Early intervention, school-based, or complex-behaviour caseloads
- Build the reliability record: attendance is a clinical variable here, not a nicety

STEP 6 — Step up MONTHS 10-12

- Senior or lead technician roles, training new RBTs
- Or start the graduate route toward BCaBA/BCBA — the tier that writes the plans you run

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: three provider postings saved — at least one says 'no experience, training provided'.
- □ Days 1–30: hired or in a training cohort; the 40-hour course underway.
- □ Days 31–60: training done; competency assessment scheduled or passed.
- □ Days 61–90: exam booked or passed; first supervised sessions running.
- □ Day 90: you're a credentialed technician with a caseload — in a field that hired you at zero.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **SMALL STEPS ARE THE WHOLE JOB.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.